sprinklers, drips, water-efficient seeds and farming practices have been set in motion. Likewise, increased chemical residues in food, fruits and vegetables have led to interventions in organic agriculture.

Agriculture has been growing at a low but reasonably steady growth rate, in excess of 3 per cent, in the past twenty years. The demand-and-supply situation for most crops has changed for the better on account of population growth at a much lower rate than agriculture. However, farmers' incomes have stagnated.

Reforms of 1990s Bypassed Agriculture

The foreign exchange crisis of 1991 did not have its roots in agriculture. The reforms of 1991 were essentially industrial sector reforms, though the depreciation of the rupee did benefit agriculture exports as well.

In 1991, despite the slew of industrial, trade and FDI reforms, no new agriculture policy was announced. Agriculture continued to be protected and no FDI was permitted in the sector. India negotiated the largest protection for agriculture when the World Trade Organization (WTO) was set up in the 1990s. The 1991–92 Budget promised continued protection of agriculture and rural development outlays at 50 per cent of Plan resources.

All agriculture development programmes were continued with varying degrees of emphasis in the post-1991 period. Though there was some minor upward adjustment of fertilizer prices, the reforms largely ignored the agriculture sector.

Direct Income Transfers Make an Entry in 2018

The government initiated a number of programmes to protect income from agriculture, including different crop insurance programmes, disaster relief and rehabilitation assistance programmes and MSPs. However, these were indirect income protection programmes.